left for Chandigarh in haste, where they met Governor A.P. Sharma (former Union minister of state for industries and later governor of West Bengal) and then at night, Chief Minister Darbara Singh. They did not attend Atwal's bhog – last rites – lest they should be accused by Atwal's family of responsibility for his murder. Incidentally, the investigation of the case was handed over to the CBI, bypassing the Punjab Police who had the original jurisdiction. Also, CBI Director J.S. Bawa was asked to personally handle the case and report directly to Indira Gandhi.

The visit to the Golden Temple from Delhi of a senior serving army officer along with a serving Punjab police officer of SP rank, and their request to a Punjab police DIG to join them would not have been done without instructions from above. It appears there was some plan afoot, which went awry with Atwal's unexpected murder.

Why did neither Punjab Police nor the CRPF not enter the Guru Nanak Niwas to capture Bhindranwale or his killer squad responsible for Atwal's murder remains an unanswered question. Darbara Singh told Mark Tully and Satish Jacob, 'I consistently told Central government that the Guru Nanak Niwas (Rest House) was not a part of the Temple complex, that the police should be sent in there. But they told me they were afraid of inflaming Sikh sentiments.' The authors conclude, 'In the national outcry that followed [Atwal's murder], very few Sikhs, except those already committed to Bhindranwale, would have raised any objection. In fact, many Sikhs, especially those living outside Punjab, would have welcomed it.' [8]

With that I fully agree.

Bhindranwale's 'hit list'

Within a couple of months of Atwal's murder two close associates of Bhindranwale's – Thara Singh and Amrik Singh (whose release was the only condition Bhindranwale asked for in November 1982 when Swaran Singh had gone to meet him) – were released from jail. Soon after his release, Amrik Singh, as president of the AISSF, called a meeting of the organization at the Golden Temple, where